

Market Attractiveness and Competitive Intensity: Germany and France High-Power DC Charging for Mid-Size Entrants 2026–2028

1 Executive Summary

Germany and France both offer strong long-term demand fundamentals for high-power DC charging, but the near-term entry window for a mid-size operator is narrowing due to rapid infrastructure buildout and entrenched incumbents. BEV sales have rebounded sharply in both markets—Germany reached 19.1% BEV share in 2025 after a post-subsidy dip, while France hit 20.0% and accelerated further with 62.9% year-on-year growth in H1 2026 [1, 2, 3]. However, infrastructure deployment has outpaced fleet growth: Germany’s EVs-per-fast-charger ratio fell from ~119 in 2023 to ~71 by mid-2025, and France’s dropped from ~79 to ~46 [4, 5, 6], signaling improving driver convenience but compressing per-charger utilisation and extending payback periods estimated at 6–12 years [7].

The competitive landscape is concentrated and well-capitalised. In Germany, EnBW leads with over 6,000 fast chargers, followed by Tesla and Aral Pulse, while the Deutschlandnetz programme channels subsidised infrastructure that raises the bar for independents [8, 9]. In France, TotalEnergies and Tesla dominate highway and near-highway segments, and Electra’s €304 million Series B underscores the capital intensity required to compete [10, 11]. Allego’s \$1.5 billion take-private by Meridiam further illustrates consolidation favoring scale players [12].

France appears marginally more attractive for a mid-size entrant, given its more fragmented operator landscape, stronger ADVENIR and France 2030 subsidy frameworks (totaling over €800 million) [13, 14], and faster BEV adoption momentum. Germany offers a larger fleet but higher competitive intensity and a more mature charging base. In either market, the entrant should target underserved corridors and retail-adjacent locations rather than prime motorway sites, and must stress-test its business case against subsidy withdrawal and sustained low utilisation through 2028.

2 Introduction and Scope

This report assesses the attractiveness of the German and French public high-power DC charging (HPC, 150 kW and above) markets for a mid-size operator planning network expansion over 2026–2028. The analysis covers demand dynamics, infrastructure supply, competitive concentration, pricing economics, regulatory frameworks, and structural risks—all scoped exclusively to passenger-car public fast charging and excluding home, workplace, bus, and truck charging.

Throughout the report, external evidence published in 2025–2026 is benchmarked against the internal IEA Global EV Data 2024 files, which provide a 2023 baseline: Germany had approximately 2.5 million EVs (BEV + PHEV) and 21,000 public fast chargers, yielding roughly 119 EVs per fast charger; France had approximately 1.57 million EVs and 20,000 public fast chargers, yielding roughly 79 EVs per fast charger; and EU27 public fast chargers grew 67% in 2023 [15, 5]. These baselines serve as the anchor for tracking how rapidly each market has evolved.

3 Demand: BEV Sales and Fleet Growth

Germany’s post-subsidy dip and recovery. Germany’s BEV market share fell sharply from 18.4% in 2023 to 13.5% in 2024 after the Umweltbonus purchase subsidy ended abruptly in December 2023, with only 380,609 BEVs registered in 2024—nearly 144,000 fewer than the prior year [16]. The recovery, however, has been robust: BEV share rebounded to a record 19.1% in full-year 2025, driven primarily by fleet and corporate purchases, with registrations growing 43.2% year-on-year [1, 17]. In the first half of 2026, approximately 368,000 BEVs were newly registered, representing a further 48% year-on-year increase [18]. A new socially graduated purchase grant of up to €6,000, introduced on 1 January 2026, has reinforced this momentum [19]. As of 1 January 2026, Germany’s BEV passenger-car fleet stood at 2,034,260 vehicles [20], up from approximately 1.5 million at end-2023 per IEA data [21].

France’s steady acceleration. France has followed a more linear growth path. BEV share rose from approximately 16.9% in 2024 to 20.0% in 2025, with plug-in vehicles collectively reaching 26.7% share [2]. ACEA confirmed French BEV registrations grew 12.5% in 2025 [17]. The acceleration intensified in 2026: H1 2026 BEV registrations surged 62.9% year-on-year [3], and August 2026 set a new monthly record at 38.8% BEV share for passenger cars [22]. Policy support has been recalibrated rather than withdrawn—the bonus écologique was replaced by a “prime coup de pouce” scheme continuing into 2026 [23], and the third edition of the social leasing programme (launched July 2026) offers 50,000 BEVs at capped monthly payments of €200 to low-income households, with government aid up to €9,500 [24]. France surpassed one million BEV passenger cars in 2024 [25], and with approximately 340,000 BEVs registered in 2025, the fleet likely reached around 1.3 million by early 2026.

Metric	Germany	France
BEV share 2023	18.4% [16]	~16.0% (est.)
BEV share 2024	13.5% [16]	~16.9% [2]
BEV share 2025	19.1% [1]	20.0% [2]
H1 2026 YoY growth	+48% [18]	+62.9% [3]
BEV fleet (Jan 2026)	~2.03 million [20]	~1.3 million (est.) [25, 21]
IEA 2023 baseline (BEV+PHEV)	~2.5 million [21, 15]	~1.57 million [21, 15]

Table: BEV Demand Trajectory in Germany and France

Cross-reference with IEA baseline. The IEA 2023 figures of ~2.5 million EVs for Germany and ~1.57 million for France include both BEVs and PHEVs [15]. The January 2026 BEV-only figure of 2.03 million for Germany [20] is consistent when accounting for the PHEV component. For France, the ~1.3 million BEV fleet at early 2026 [25] similarly aligns with the IEA’s 980,000 BEV stock at end-2023 [21] plus subsequent registrations. Both markets show strong demand trajectories into 2028, though Germany’s path has been more volatile due to subsidy disruption.

4 Supply: DC Fast-Charging Infrastructure and Coverage Ratios

Germany’s infrastructure surge. Germany’s DC fast-charging network has expanded dramatically from the IEA 2023 baseline of approximately 21,000 points [5]. The Bundesnetzagentur reported 40,777 DC fast-charging points as of July 2025 [4], rising to 48,729 by January 2026 [26] and 54,341 by July 2026 [27]. This represents growth of approximately 159% over the 2023 baseline in just two and a half years [27]. The fast-charging share of total public charging points rose from around 13% in 2020 to approximately 26% by mid-2026 [27], reflecting a deliberate policy and market shift toward higher-power infrastructure.

France’s HPC expansion. France’s high-power charging network (150 kW and above) has also grown rapidly. Avere-France reported 31,335 HPC points by end of February 2025, a 58% increase from 19,848 in February 2024 [6]. Total public charging points reached 177,180 by August 2025 [28]. It is important to note a definitional difference: the IEA 2023 baseline of ~20,000 “fast chargers” for France uses a threshold of >22 kW [5], whereas the Avere-France HPC figure of 31,335 applies a stricter 150 kW+ threshold [6]. This means France’s total DC fast-charging stock (including 50–149 kW chargers) is substantially larger than the HPC-only count, and direct comparison with the IEA baseline requires caution.

Declining EVs-per-charger ratios. The most striking finding is that infrastructure buildout has outpaced fleet growth in both markets. Germany’s ratio improved from approximately 119 EVs per fast charger in 2023 [5] to roughly 71 by mid-2025 [4]. France’s ratio improved from approximately 79 [5] to around 46 EVs per HPC point by early 2025 [6, 29]. While lower ratios signal better driver convenience, they also raise questions about near-term utilisation and revenue per charger for operators.

Chart Explanation: This chart compares the EVs-per-public-fast-charger ratio in Germany and France between the IEA 2023 baseline and the latest available data. Germany’s ratio fell from ~119 to ~71 [4, 5], and France’s from ~79 to ~46 [6, 29, 5], demonstrating that infrastructure deployment has significantly outpaced fleet growth in both markets—a signal of improving coverage but also potential near-term oversupply risk.

5 Competitive Landscape and Market Concentration

Germany: EnBW dominates, followed by Tesla. The German HPC market is led by EnBW, which operated 6,005 fast chargers at end-2024, adding 355 in December 2024 alone [8]. By mid-2025, EnBW’s total public charging network reached 9,297 points (including AC), far ahead of E.ON at 4,511, Tesla at 3,388, and EWE Go at 2,769 [30]. Tesla ranks second in fast charging specifically, with 3,110 HPC chargers at end-2024, having opened its Supercharger network to non-Tesla vehicles [8]. Aral Pulse (bp) held third position with 2,317 fast chargers, followed by Allego at 1,541 and Ionity at 1,084 [8]. The top five operators collectively account for a substantial majority of Germany’s fast-charging capacity, indicating moderate-to-high concentration.

France: segmented by location type. The French market is more segmented by geography. On motorways, TotalEnergies leads with 850 charging points and 380 MW of installed capacity, leveraging its extensive fuel-station network [10]. Ionity follows with 688 highway points, then ENGIE Vianeo (632), Electra (323), and Fastned (265) [10]. In the critical near-highway segment, Tesla dominates with 2,453 charging points (574 MW), using a strategy of acquiring land near highway exits for faster rollouts [10]. Electra is a fast-rising French player with 1,181 near-highway points and 323 on highways, totalling approximately 1,504 HPC points in France as of May 2025 [10]. In urban and retail locations, Powerdot leads with 2,116 points, followed by Izivia/EDF (865) and IECharge (597)

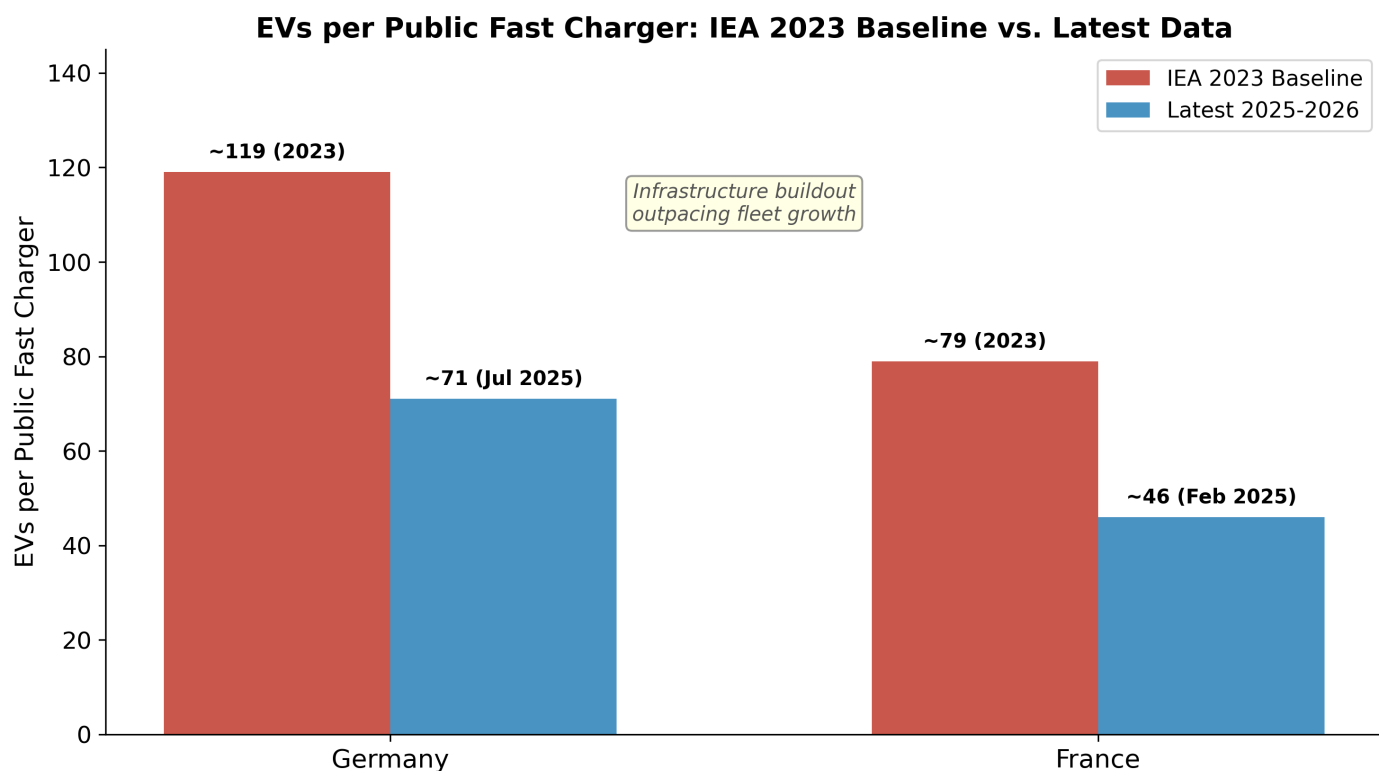


Figure 1: EVs per Public Fast Charger: IEA 2023 Baseline vs. Latest Data

[10]. France's highway HPC network grew from just 484 points in 2021 to 3,626 by May 2025, covering nearly all motorway service areas [10].

Chart Explanation: This chart shows the top five HPC operators by charging-point count in Germany (end-2024) and France (May 2025, combining highway and near-highway segments). EnBW's commanding lead in Germany [8] and Tesla's dominance in France's near-highway segment [10] illustrate the different competitive dynamics in each market.

Recent M&A and funding activity. The European EV charging sector has seen significant capital flows. Meridiam acquired Allego for approximately \$1.5 billion in mid-2024 (an 8.6× revenue multiple on roughly \$170 million in revenue), completing a voluntary delisting from the NYSE [12, 31]. Paris-based Electra raised €304 million in a Series B round to expand its European fast-charging network [11]. Ionity, backed by a consortium of major automakers (BMW, Mercedes, Ford, Hyundai/Kia, VW Group), is targeting 1,500 ultra-fast charging sites across 13 European countries by 2026 [32]. Digital platform &Charge raised a €5 million Series A in April 2026 to support CPOs including Ionity, Electra, and Allego [33]. Shell Recharge, while maintaining 1,143 fast chargers in Germany at end-2024, showed modest growth of only 46 units in December 2024, reflecting Shell's broader strategic review of its EV charging portfolio [8]. These transactions signal that well-capitalised incumbents are consolidating, raising the bar for new entrants.

6 Pricing, Revenue Economics, and Utilisation Signals

Ad-hoc pricing. Germany's median ad-hoc fast-charging price stands at approximately €0.59/kWh across more than 200 CPOs, placing it 21st out of 29 European countries ranked by lowest median price [34]. Key operator rates in Germany include Ionity at €0.55/kWh via app without subscription, EnBW DC at approximately €0.46–0.63/kWh, and UTA/Shell DC at around €0.66/kWh [35]. In France, pricing varies more widely: Electra charges €0.39–0.61/kWh via its app using dynamic pricing, and €0.69/kWh for ad-hoc credit-card payments [36, 37]. Tesla Superchargers in France range from approximately €0.40–0.50/kWh with an account to around €0.62/kWh without one [38].

Subscription models. Subscription tiers offer meaningful discounts. Ionity's tiered plans reduce prices from €0.55/kWh (no subscription) to €0.39/kWh at €5.99/month and €0.33/kWh at €11.99/month [39]. Tesla's membership at €11.99/month further reduces dynamic prices [34]. However, only 35% of top CPOs in Germany offer any subscription or membership tier, and two-thirds of all CPO entries have no membership option at all [34], limiting revenue predictability for smaller operators.

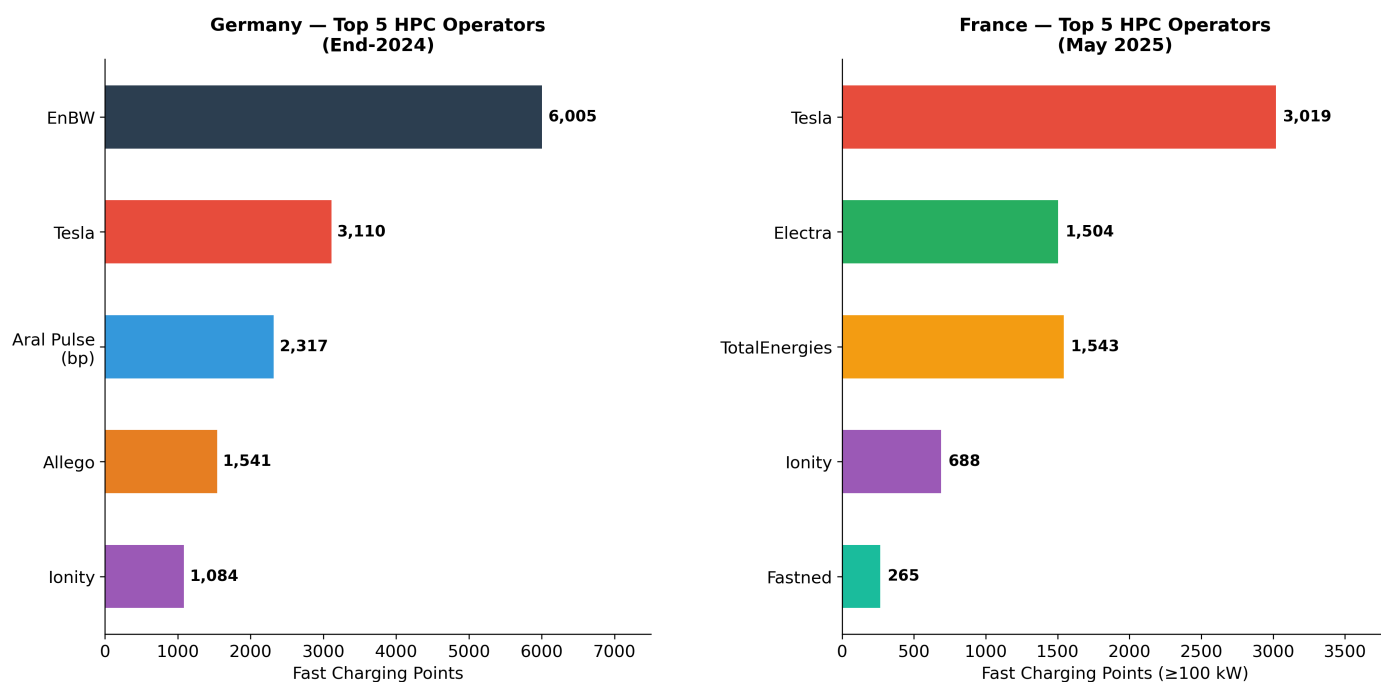


Figure 2: Top HPC Operators in Germany and France

Price trends and utilisation. Prices have trended slightly upward: Ionity raised prices by an average of 4% across its European network effective July 2026 [40], and EU wholesale electricity prices rose approximately 10% year-on-year in 2025 [41]. On the utilisation side, DC fast chargers service roughly three times as many vehicles per charge point as AC chargers, with approximately 40 kWh per session and an average session duration of around 45 minutes [42]. Tesla leads in per-charger utilisation across Europe, but overall public charger utilisation remains low for most operators [43]. Germany's overall ratio of 17 EVs per public charging point (including AC) [44] suggests that while demand is growing, the installed base is expanding faster—a dynamic that compresses per-charger revenue and extends payback periods. Industry estimates place payback periods for charging stations at 6–12 years, influenced by solar integration, policy support, and grid reliability [7].

7 Regulatory Framework and Policy Support

EU AFIR mandates. The Alternative Fuels Infrastructure Regulation (AFIR) sets binding targets for all EU member states. Each registered BEV must be supported by at least 1.3 kW of publicly accessible recharging capacity, and each PHEV by at least 0.80 kW [45]. On the TEN-T core network, member states must deploy recharging pools of at least 400 kW (including at least one 150 kW point) every 60 km by 31 December 2025. By 31 December 2027, each pool must reach 600 kW with at least two 150 kW points. The TEN-T comprehensive network must achieve at least 300 kW pools on half its length by end-2027 and full coverage by end-2030 [45]. These mandates create a guaranteed demand floor for HPC infrastructure but also impose compliance costs and technical standards that new entrants must meet.

Germany: Deutschlandnetz. The Deutschlandnetz programme is the centrepiece of Germany's fast-charging strategy. It currently encompasses more than 1,000 locations with approximately 9,000 charging points, each delivering at least 200 kW [9]. The Deutschlandnetz II motorway concession programme is progressing: as of June 2026, the Autostrom Plus consortium had 50 of its 99 allocated motorway fast-charging parks operational, covering nearly half of all charging parks at unmanaged rest areas along German motorways [46]. The EU Commission also approved €1.6 billion in German state aid for electric heavy-duty vehicle fast-charging infrastructure on motorways [47], signalling the scale of public investment flowing into the sector. For a new entrant, the Deutschlandnetz creates both opportunity (as a potential concession partner) and risk (as a source of subsidised competition).

France: ADVENIR and France 2030. France's ADVENIR programme has been extended to end-2027 with an additional €200 million envelope, bringing the total budget to approximately €520 million and targeting 250,000 funded charging points; since 2016, the programme has financed nearly 175,000 points [13, 48]. The France 2030 investment plan allocated €300 million for charging infrastructure deployment, covering up to 40% of eligible costs [14]. In May 2026, President Macron announced operator commitments to deploy 240,000 additional charging points by 2030, including 60,000 fast and ultra-fast points [49]. A new motorway master plan targets approxi-

mately 30,000 fast-charging points by 2035, comprising 22,000 for passenger cars at 150 kW across nearly 900 service areas [50]. However, France reached 200,045 public charging points as of July 2026, and the installation pace dropped 27% year-on-year in H1 2026, putting the 400,000-point 2030 target under pressure [51]. France also offered a 75% reduction in grid-connection costs for charging infrastructure included in validated master plans (SDIRVE) through end-2025 [52], though the status of this incentive beyond 2025 is uncertain.

8 Key Risks and Market Entry Barriers

Grid connection costs and delays. Securing grid connections remains one of the most significant operational bottlenecks for new charging operators. Connection timelines can stretch to 12–18 months in congested areas, and costs vary widely depending on local grid capacity. France’s 75% grid-connection cost reduction for validated master plans [52] has helped, but this incentive’s extension beyond 2025 is not confirmed. Germany’s €1.6 billion state aid for HDV charging infrastructure [47] signals public investment but also regulatory complexity that favours established players with permitting experience.

Capital intensity and long payback periods. Europe’s total EV charging build-out may cost upward of €240 billion cumulatively by 2030 [53]. At the individual operator level, payback periods of 6–12 years [7] demand patient capital and strong balance sheets. With utilisation rates still low for most operators and per-charger revenue compressed by the rapid infrastructure buildout, a mid-size entrant faces a prolonged cash-burn phase before reaching profitability.

Competitive moats of incumbents. Grocery retailers such as Lidl, ALDI, and Kaufland are among Europe’s cheapest charging operators, subsidising charging to drive foot traffic—a competitive moat that pure-play operators cannot easily replicate [34]. They benefit from existing land, parking infrastructure, and often sufficient grid connections. Similarly, utility-backed CPOs bundle home electricity contracts with public charging discounts, creating vertical integration advantages and customer lock-in that independent operators struggle to match [34].

Declining EVs-per-charger ratios and oversupply risk. The sharp improvement in EVs-per-charger ratios—from 119 to 71 in Germany and from 79 to 46 in France—is positive for drivers but concerning for operator economics. If infrastructure continues to outpace fleet growth through 2028, utilisation rates may remain depressed, particularly in non-highway locations where dwell-time competition with AC charging is strongest.

Subsidy and policy dependency. Both markets remain sensitive to policy shifts. Germany’s experience with the abrupt Umweltbonus cancellation in December 2023 [16] demonstrates how quickly demand can contract when incentives are withdrawn. France’s installation pace slowdown of 27% in H1 2026 [51] suggests that even with supportive policy frameworks, execution can falter. A new entrant must stress-test its business case against scenarios where subsidies are reduced or delayed.

9 Conclusion: Market Attractiveness Assessment

Germany and France both present substantial long-term demand fundamentals for high-power DC charging, with BEV sales accelerating strongly into 2026 and fleet sizes growing toward critical mass. However, the near-term picture for a mid-size entrant is challenging.

Germany offers the larger fleet (2.03 million BEVs) and a proven policy framework through the Deutschlandnetz, but the market is more concentrated around well-capitalised incumbents like EnBW and Tesla, and the EVs-per-fast-charger ratio has already fallen to approximately 71, suggesting that the infrastructure gap is closing rapidly. The median ad-hoc price of €0.59/kWh provides reasonable revenue potential, but competition from subsidised grocery-retailer charging and utility bundles compresses margins.

France presents a somewhat less crowded HPC landscape with a lower EVs-per-charger ratio (~46) and stronger near-term BEV sales momentum (+62.9% in H1 2026). The ADVENIR programme and France 2030 subsidies offer meaningful capital-cost offsets, and the motorway master plan creates a visible pipeline of concession opportunities. However, the 27% installation-pace slowdown in H1 2026 and the dominance of TotalEnergies and Tesla in key highway and near-highway segments represent significant barriers.

For a mid-size entrant, France may offer marginally better positioning due to its more fragmented competitive structure, stronger subsidy support, and faster BEV adoption trajectory. Germany, while larger in absolute terms, presents higher competitive intensity and a more mature infrastructure base. In either market, the entrant should target underserved segments—such as secondary highway corridors, urban charging hubs near retail destinations, or partnerships with fleet operators—rather than competing head-to-head with incumbents on prime motorway locations. The 2026–2028 window remains viable, but the window is narrowing as incumbents scale and EVs-per-charger ratios continue to decline.

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